limitations” for nations outside the Western Hemisphere. There was no mention of Turkey, Italy, or Britain by name. The statement was a setback not only for Kennedy but also for Khrushchev, who had no idea either of the president’s real position on the issue or of the difficulties he had created for Kennedy by making his statement public.[16]

For the first time since the start of the crisis, Kennedy found himself closer to Khrushchev than to his own aides. Khrushchev had offered a deal that Kennedy was ready to accept. The question was whether he could do so politically. He was the only member of ExCom prepared to make the deal: everyone else was opposed. However, it was not only a question of the revolt of Kennedy’s aides but also of the publicity accompanying Khrushchev’s offer. Kennedy could not accept a public deal that would make him look weak, accommodating Khrushchev’s whims and backing off from his original position. It was no less important to assure the NATO allies that he was not betraying them so as to shield himself and his country from the Soviet nuclear threat, with which the Europeans had lived for years.

It was a trap. Kennedy could not accept the Turkish “gift” that Khrushchev was offering him because it would require “ungifting” the missiles his predecessor had given to Turkey—a political impossibility. The two leaders were prepared and even eager to make a deal, but one of them had presented it in such a way that the other could not take it.